

Empiricism



British empiricist philosophy was influenced by the method of observation and experiment of the natural sciences, as opposed to the pure reasoning of mathematics that inspired continental rationalism.

Advances in science during the Age of Reason had a very different influence on British philosophy to that of mainland Europe. Reacting against the rationalism of Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz, British philosophers dismissed the idea that reason is our only reliable source of knowledge and developed the opposing movement known as empiricism. While not denying that reasoning is important to *assessing* information, the

empiricists believed that the source of that information is the outside world, accessed through our senses. British empiricists were particularly influenced by Francis Bacon's scientific methodology of observation, analysis and experiment (see [Bacon and the scientific method](#)), which contrasted with the mathematically inspired reasoning of the continental rationalists. In the 17th century, Thomas Hobbes laid the foundations of modern empiricism with his materialist and mechanistic views – although its roots could be traced back to Aristotle, it was now reinforced by scientific advances and soon became established as the dominant philosophy of the English-speaking world.